Annual program summary | Reporting year 2025

Smart Salting Summary 2025

Results of the district's winter maintenance training for city crews, school districts and private applicators, with the 2026 workshop schedule and cost-share program

Published May 20, 2026. Prepared by the district's water resources program for the Board of Managers.

22%
less salt used by trained organizations in the 2024-25 winter than in 2023-24

871 tons
less salt applied by those organizations: 3,089 tons, down from 3,960

146
people completed a Smart Salting course in fall 2025

12
cost-share awards for spreader calibration equipment in 2025

The district's Smart Salting training shows winter maintenance crews how to keep streets, parking lots and sidewalks safe with less salt. It is free for people who work in the district, including city public works crews, school district grounds staff, snow-removal contractors, property managers, homeowners association boards and places of worship. The course covers spreader calibration, pretreatment and application rates.

Organizations whose staff completed the training in fall 2024 reported using 22% less salt in the 2024-25 winter than in the 2023-24 winter. Thirty-seven organizations returned records for both winters. Together they applied 3,089 tons of salt in 2024-25, down from 3,960 tons the winter before.

The reduction came in a winter with more frequent snow and ice than the unusually mild winter before it. Over the same two winters, the district's annual survey of member cities found that city street crews as a whole used 9% more road salt.

This summary also reports the training the district delivered in 2025, the 2025 cost-share awards, the 2026 cost-share program and the fall 2026 workshop schedule.

In this summary

1. The program 2
2. Salt use before and after training 2
3. Training delivered in 2025 4
4. Cost-share for spreader calibration equipment 4
5. Workshop schedule, fall 2026 5
Contacts and suggested citation 5

1. The program

Smart Salting is the district's training program for people who plow and treat pavement in winter. District staff teach every course, and every course is free for people who work in the district.

Each course covers how salt melts ice and why it stops working at low pavement temperatures, pretreating pavement with brine before a storm, calibrating spreaders, choosing an application rate by pavement temperature and conditions, sweeping up leftover salt, storing salt under cover and keeping records. A participant completes a course by attending the full session and passing a short end-of-course quiz.

Course	Length	Who it is for
Roads and streets	Full day	City crews and contractors who plow and treat streets.
Parking lots and sidewalks	Half day	Contractors, property managers, homeowners association boards, places of worship and anyone who treats lots and walks.
School grounds and facilities	Half day	School district grounds and custodial staff.
Spreader calibration clinic	Three hours, hands-on	Any crew. Bring a truck or walk-behind spreader, and staff help calibrate it so the setting matches the amount of salt that comes out.
Refresher	Two hours, online	Anyone who has completed a Smart Salting course.

2. Salt use before and after training

Table 1 compares the salt each organization applied in the 2023-24 winter, before its staff took the training, with the 2024-25 winter, the first winter after it. It covers the 37 organizations that returned records for both winters. All four groups used less salt.

Table 1. Salt applied by organizations whose staff completed the training in fall 2024

Group	Organizations reporting	2023-24 winter (tons)	2024-25 winter (tons)	Change (tons)	Change (%)
City public works crews	5	2,615	2,147	-468	-17.9%
School districts	3	268	196	-72	-26.9%
Snow-removal contractors	14	846	584	-262	-31.0%
Property managers, HOAs and places of worship	15	231	162	-69	-29.9%
All reporting organizations	**37**	**3,960**	**3,089**	**-871**	**-22.0%**

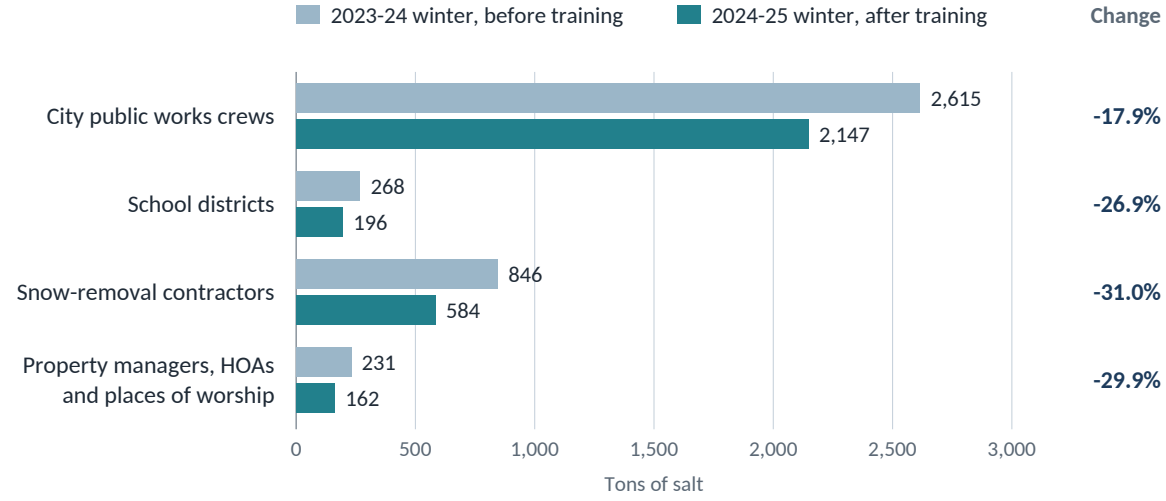
Tons are short tons (2,000 pounds) of salt, including the salt in brine and treated products, as reported by each organization from its purchase, delivery or loading records.

How the figures were gathered

- When they registered for the fall 2024 workshops, organizations reported the salt they applied in the 2023-24 winter.
- After the 2024-25 winter, the district asked the same organizations for that winter's total, taken from the same kind of records.
- District staff compared each return with the organization's registration form and followed up on any total that changed by more than half.

- In fall 2024, 154 people from 58 organizations completed a course. Of those organizations, 37 returned records for both winters and are counted in Table 1. The other 21 are not included; most were small property managers and contractors.

Figure 1. Salt applied by group, 2023-24 and 2024-25 winters (tons)



Bars start at zero. Change is the 2024-25 total compared with the 2023-24 total for each group.

What organizations changed

In the follow-up survey, organizations also said what they did differently in the 2024-25 winter.

Table 2. Practices reported by the 37 organizations in Table 1

Change reported after the training	Organizations	Share of 37
Calibrated spreaders before or during the season	31	84%
Set application rates by pavement temperature	26	70%
Swept up leftover salt after storms	22	59%
Pretreated pavement with brine before storms	12	32%
Moved salt storage under cover	9	24%

Weather and the city survey

The figures are not adjusted for weather. The 2023-24 winter was unusually mild, with little snow, and the 2024-25 winter brought more frequent snow and ice events, so weather alone would have pushed salt use up rather than down.

The district's annual survey of member cities found that city street crews as a whole used 9% more road salt in the 2024-25 winter than in 2023-24. The survey covers all city streets. This summary covers only the organizations in Table 1, most of which treat parking lots, sidewalks and school grounds.

Limits of these figures

Salt totals are reported by the organizations from their own records and checked by district staff for completeness. The organizations in Table 1 chose to take the training and to report, so they are not a sample of all salt users in the district. The figures should not be used to estimate total salt use in the district or any group's share of it.

3. Training delivered in 2025

In fall 2025 the district held seven sessions, with 171 attendees from 66 organizations. Of the attendees, 146 completed a course, and crews at the calibration clinic calibrated 23 spreaders.

Table 3. Smart Salting sessions, fall 2025

Date	Course	Format and place	Attendees	Completed
Tue., Sept. 16, 2025	Roads and streets	Full day, district office	26	25
Thu., Sept. 18, 2025	Parking lots and sidewalks	Half day, district office	29	27
Wed., Sept. 24, 2025	Spreader calibration clinic	Hands-on, district office yard	16	n/a
Tue., Oct. 7, 2025	Roads and streets	Full day, district office	24	23
Thu., Oct. 9, 2025	Parking lots and sidewalks (evening session)	Half day, district office	33	30
Wed., Oct. 15, 2025	School grounds and facilities	Half day, district office	21	20
Tue., Oct. 28, 2025	Parking lots and sidewalks	Half day, online	22	21
Fall 2025 total	**7 sessions**		**171**	**146**

The calibration clinic is hands-on and has no end-of-course quiz, so it has no completion count.

Results for the organizations trained in fall 2025, comparing the 2025-26 winter with 2024-25, will be reported in the Smart Salting Summary 2026. Those organizations can return their 2025-26 records through June 30, 2026.

4. Cost-share for spreader calibration equipment

The district shares the cost of equipment that helps crews calibrate spreaders and put salt down at a set rate.

- **Who can apply.** Organizations that maintain streets, parking lots or sidewalks in the district and have at least one staff member who has completed a Smart Salting course in the past five years.
- **What it pays.** Up to 50% of the cost of eligible equipment, up to $4,000 per organization per year.
- **Eligible equipment.** Spreader calibration kits (portable scales, catch pans or tarps and rate charts), ground-speed controls for truck-mounted spreaders, walk-behind spreaders with marked rate settings, and handheld infrared pavement thermometers.
- **Not eligible.** Salt, brine and other deicers, vehicles, plows, labor, and equipment bought before an award is approved.

2025 awards

The Board of Managers approved 12 awards in July 2025, ranging from $640 to $4,000. Recipients bought ground-speed controls for nine trucks, 14 calibration kits and 27 walk-behind spreaders.

2026 applications

Applications open Monday, June 1, and are due Friday, June 26, 2026. The Board of Managers will consider awards at its July meeting. Recipients are asked to report how they used the equipment after the 2026-27 winter. Guidelines and the application form are at metrolakeswd.org/smartsalting.

5. Workshop schedule, fall 2026

All fall 2026 workshops are free for people who work in the district. Registration opens in early September at metrolakeswd.org/smartsalting. Seats are limited, and every session requires advance registration. Dates can change, so check the registration page for the current schedule.

Table 4. Smart Salting workshops, fall 2026

Date (2026)	Time	Course	Who it is for	Where
Tue., Sept. 22	8 a.m. to 3:30 p.m.	Roads and streets	City crews and contractors who plow and treat streets	District office
Thu., Sept. 24	8 a.m. to 12:30 p.m.	Parking lots and sidewalks	Contractors, property managers and grounds crews	District office
Wed., Sept. 30	9 a.m. to noon	Spreader calibration clinic	Any crew. Bring a truck or walk-behind spreader.	District office yard
Tue., Oct. 6	8 a.m. to 3:30 p.m.	Roads and streets	City crews and contractors who plow and treat streets	District office
Thu., Oct. 8	6 to 9 p.m.	Parking lots and sidewalks (evening session)	HOA boards, places of worship and property managers	District office
Wed., Oct. 14	8 a.m. to 12:30 p.m.	School grounds and facilities	School district grounds and custodial staff	District office
Tue., Oct. 20	9 to 11 a.m.	Refresher	Anyone who has completed a Smart Salting course	Online, live
Tue., Oct. 27	8 a.m. to 12:30 p.m.	Parking lots and sidewalks	Contractors, property managers and grounds crews	Online, live

In-person courses meet in the district office training room. The calibration clinic meets in the district office yard.

Contacts and suggested citation

Smart Salting workshops and cost-share: metrolakeswd.org/smartsalting
Media: Luis Ferreira (he/him), Communications Coordinator, (651) 555-0158, luis.ferreira@metrolakeswd.org

Suggested citation: Metro Lakes Watershed District. Smart Salting Summary 2025. May 20, 2026. metrolakeswd.org/reports/smart-salting-2025.

About the district. The Metro Lakes Watershed District is a local unit of government governed by a Board of Managers. It monitors the lakes, ponds and streams of its member cities and works with cities, schools and businesses to keep salt and other pollutants out of them. Reports, budgets and Board agendas are posted at metrolakeswd.org.